



Development Journey of Pakistan from 1947 to 2026

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A state comes into being to bring in the development and prosperity of its people. For that sake, the state has to develop on all fronts. If it chalks out sound policies, defines a right direction of development. Pakistan also was supposed to facilitate the subjugated people of the subcontinent on multiple fronts of life. However, the development journey of the nation has not been up to the mark. Nearly all the institutions of the society have achieved little in this respect. It lags behind on numerous social and economic indicators. ***It ranks 168th out of 193 countries on the UN's Human Development Index. On the Rule of Law Index, it ranks 130th out of 142 countries.*** On the other hand, nations like China, Bangladesh and many Western nations have stood successful in terms of development. China is going to be the leading economy of the world in the near future. Bangladesh is one of the fastest growing economies of the world. The Western countries are enjoying the zenith of technology. These development models could be taken as lessons for successful progress. Pakistan could learn lessons from them, but it did little. For learning lessons from the other countries, the state and society will have to look at various successful development models across the world.

To begin with the development journey, the institutions of Pakistan were inadequate from the day one-August 14, 1947. Had there been strong institutions the constitutional development would

have not consumed nine precious years. The society also did not take responsibility to strengthen the state institutions. Moreover, in the course of history there happened a lot of undemocratic incidents that shaped a dismal picture of the country. ***The case of Mohtrama Fatima Jinnah, when she was subjected to character assassination during contesting elections against a dictator, can be quoted as an example in this regard.*** More than that the country has not achieved fully fledged success in terms of institutional development yet. There hardly seems separation of power in the country. The government, the parliament, and the judiciary are found overreaching their respective circles. Hence, the development journey of the nation has achieved little.

The economic development journey of Pakistan has also been in trouble. The country inherited a very weak institution of economy with few financial assets. After Quaid-e-Azam, no leadership has been able to make economic policies in a better way. ***From the 1950s to 1960s, the institution of economy experienced a significant growth i.e. 6 per cent GDP growth rate.*** But, later on the cycle of economic growth did not continue. Our economy, once again, got some momentum during the 2000s. But, again, it lost its level of 5-6 per cent average growth. Again in 2017 growth rose up to 6 per cent. In early 2022, the GDP growth was 4.9 per cent, but suddenly it experienced a nosedive in it. Today, the economy of the country is on the ventilator of foreign aid, and on the brink of bankruptcy. Hence, the development journey of the economy has been in trouble.

Social development journey has not been up to the mark since Pakistan's freedom. Many social development programmes were launched by the respective governments, but none achieved much in this respect. Slogans such as "***roti, kapra aor makaan***" in the 1970s, and "***qarz utaro mulk sanwaro***" in the 1990s, did not prove unsuccessful in practical. "***Hamara khwab parha likha pubjab,***" in the 2000s, was not a nationwide initiative, and that it earned little success. The contemporary slogans such as "***Ihsas Programme,***" and "***Uraan Pakistan***" have also proved little productive. So the policies regarding social security have been little fruitful yet. The issue is every coming government replaces the policies of the previous government. Today, ***Pakistan ranks 109th out of 127 on the Global Hunger Index. It secures an unsatisfactory position in the Global Healthcare Index.*** It lags far behind on education with ***60-63 per cent literacy rate.*** More than ***40 per cent of the population is living below the poverty line.*** So, the social development journey of the country has been little productive at all.

Constitutional development has been full of ups and downs across the eight decades of history. Post independence, the country used to follow the Indian Act of 1935 and Independence Act of 1947. It took nine years to conclude the first constitution of Pakistan in 1956. The equation of East Pakistan and the nature of state created uncertainty regarding constitution making. That uncertainty allowed undemocratic forces to penetrate into the domain of democratic institutions. ***On October 7, 1958, Governor-general Iskandar Mirza abrogated the first constitution of the country.*** Later on Gen. Khan enforced another constitution in 1962 by an executive order. Eventually, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto gave the third and final constitution 'the Constitution of 1973, meant to address the reservations of communities across the country. ***The 1973 constitution was also suspended by Gen. Zia in the 1070s,*** and then ***by Gen. Musharraf in 1999,*** by applying 8th and 17th constitutional amendments respectively. However, a remarkable ***18th constitutional amendment,*** finally, blocked all the ways of abrogation of the constitution, for ***it has curtailed the presidential power of 58(2)(B)--dissolving elected assemblies.*** Now ***26th and 27th constitutional amendments*** have also raised questions about the constitutional development of the country. So, the country has been experiencing a roller-coaster journey of constitutional development.

Pakistan has been experiencing turns and twists in terms of foreign policy. Quaid-e-Azam set in a proper direction of foreign policy where it was clearly mentioned that the country would create friendly relations with the nations of the world. Initially, the country met with external security challenges. To handle those challenges, it went for alliance making with world powers. ***The country decided to join the US camp, and concluded SEATO and CENTO in 1954 and 1955 respectively.*** In the 1960s, it concluded a border equation with China, and supported it on permanent membership of UNSC. As a result, it received some sort of help in return during the War of 1965. ***With Russia, the country had sour relations during the 1960s and 80s. However, in the 1970s USSR agreed upon establishing a steel mill there at Karachi.*** Viz-a-viz relations with Muslim nations, it has maintained the status quo duly given by our founding father. Post 9/11 to date, the country has not been able to cash fully fledged relations either with Russia or the US to secure national interest. Thus, the foreign policy of the country has hardly been neutral in the course of history. However, Pakistan can learn lessons from the successful models of the world such as China, Bangladesh, and even Sri Lanka that have taken off from the menace of poverty and weak economy.

The discussion, however, does not stop on this point. There must be solutions where there are problems. Only the strong institutions can do their work within their circle. If the judiciary adjudicates any law, there remains no question of disobeying it by the executive. So is the case with the functions of the legislature and executive. The society should learn from the examples of ***Nogals Arizona of the US and Nogals Sonora of Mexico, mentioned in the book "Why Nations Fail," where the former is a prosperous society due to strong institutions while the latter is not.*** The point is Pakistan will have to strengthen its state institutions to go for development.

The country needs to review its socio-economic policies. The policies should be implemented in practical ways. The issue of poverty should be tackled by giving subsidies to the poor. The poor working class and small farmers should be given subsidies on multiple areas of living. The government should cut the budget not from the soft areas like petrol, but from the hard ones such as cartels, MPs & MNAs, and higher grade bureaucrats. There are dozens of areas in the budget to cut from instead of putting burden only on the poor class. The National Security Policy, introduced by the previous government, should be implemented in toto.

Our society needs to develop political culture among the masses. Only a developed political culture turns the development around. Through awareness campaigns with the help of education, the development of a sound political culture is possible. So long as there is a dented political culture, the society is not going to be developed. Fortunately, the country is experiencing some sort of political culture right now. But, ongoing political awareness would take time. By the way, it should be kept alive as a ray of hope.

The Foreign policy of the country needs to be reviewed very critically, for it is foreign policy which takes care of national interest. Only an independent foreign policy protects national interest. The country need not repeat mistakes of the past, where it joined either of the camps with time. Because, taking one side means opposing the other one. It adds to the enemies. So, foreign policy should be independent. More than that, it should be people centric. Only then will be a strong and progressive Pakistan.

To be precise, since inception, Pakistan started the journey of development. Being laden with numerous socio-economic and political burdens, it has met failure on multiple fronts. Unlike its contemporary nations like China, and many others, it has achieved little. It could learn lessons from the successful development models, but it has not. The supposed development is much needed for the country. Seventy nine years are enough for development. How long our society will suffer social and political ills. This desperate situation will cost the country a lot. Now it is society's turn to get the

country on track. The available system with some changes can keep the momentum continued. Along with this, a mega reforms agenda can turn the tide. In this age of globalization the status of a society can easily be turned to either side. Means that, we can turn the tide very easily. Just, there is a need for will power.

